language. They are mostly situated in the north, especially along the borders with Syria, Turkey and Iran (see the map on page 116). There are millions of Kurds inside these neighbouring countries as well as in Iraq itself. However, the Iraqi Kurds were probably the most organised. Ever since the state of Iraq was created in 1921, the Kurds enjoyed a certain amount of autonomy or self-rule, but many of their leaders were determined to achieve a separate homeland, Kurdistan. There had been almost constant conflict between Iraqi troops and Kurdish nationalist fighters since the state of Iraq had been created.

During the 1970s, the Iranian government assisted the Iraqi Kurds in their struggle. They did this in order to weaken the state of Iraq which they saw as a rival. When Iran and Iraq went to war in 1980, this aid was increased and some of the Kurdish nationalist forces supported Iran. The Kurdish fighters often planned their attacks against Iraqi forces, in co-ordination with the Iranians, so as to coincide with Iranian offensives. In this way, they gained more control over the Kurdish north of Iraq. Not surprisingly, the Iraqi government of Saddam Hussein felt they were being stabbed in the back by their own people.

In 1988 the Iraqi forces took their revenge. Their planes bombarded the Kurdish town of Halabja, in northern Iraq, with chemical weapons. Five thousand people were killed immediately; 12,000 are estimated to have died later. One reporter wrote:

> Dead bodies – human and animal – littered the streets, huddled in doorways, slumped over the steering wheels of their cars. Survivors stumbled around, laughing hysterically, before collapsing. Those who had been directly exposed to the gas found that their symptoms worsened as the night wore on. Many children died along the way and were abandoned where they fell.
>
> (Quoted in D. McDowall, *A Modern History of the Kurds*, 2004.)

This was one of the episodes for which Saddam Hussein was later put on trial, found guilty and executed.

Key date
Iraqi forces attacked Halabja with chemical weapons: 1988

Saddam's solution to the 'Kurdish problem'

When the war with Iran ended in 1988, Saddam decided to solve the 'Kurdish problem' once and for all. He set out to depopulate much of the Kurdish north and destroy the Kurdish nationalist movement. His cousin, later nicknamed 'Chemical Ali' by the Kurds, was put in charge. Among the many documents and recordings later captured by the Americans, there is one recording in which he is heard saying to government officials: 'I will kill them all with chemical weapons! Who is going to say anything? The international community? F— them!'

Helicopters flew in low to kill all living things, animal as well as human, using a variety of chemical weapons. Where ground troops were used, Kurdish men aged 15–50 years were targeted: they were rounded up, shot and pushed into pre-dug graves. More than 100,000 refugees poured over the border, mostly into Turkey. Bulldozers flattened whole villages. About 180,000 were